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SOCIAL FORMATIONS IN EARLY HISTORIC ORISSA

Laxmi Kanta Mishra

In a recent debate initiated by Irfan Habib on caste system in India, he asserted that "the real upholders and the beneficiaries of the caste system in India were not so much the Brahmins as the ruling classes, which is why the exclusively anti-Brahmin orientation of the contemporary dalit movement was so inapposite".[1] Substantiating the moot point of the debate Shireen Moosvi tried to highlight "how even the Muslim rulers in early Medieval India adjusted themselves and lent support to the caste system in India. This may appear strange at first sight given the egalitarian thrust of Islam. But this egalitarianism came in the way of unequal treatment meted out to the slaves enrolled from among the conquered people by Muslim rulers everywhere in the world. And treating the oppressed castes in the same manner as slaves was but an easy transition for the Medieval Indian rulers. Where there were exceptions, such as with Muhammad Tughlaq, under whose reign many from lower castes were able to climb up to occupy important positions, the reason had to do with the exigencies of the situation rather than any conviction that caste divisions deserved to be set aside."[2] Further elaborating on this point Moosvi pointed out that "the relationship between the caste system and the state has been a crucial one for both institutions in India. While Ashoka might have ignored castes-whether *Varna* or *jati* in his inscriptions, at least from the second century A.D. prevention of admixture of the caste" had become a recognized obligation for rulers. To a degree the Dharmashastra texts too prescribed this among the ruler's duties as did the *Arthashastra*".[3]

In the context of the ensuing debate the early historic social formations in Odisha need further investigations. The point of discussion in the present paper is to understand the dynamism of social complexities and the failure on the part of the Mauryan 'Metropolitan state' to extend its power over the peripheral territories in Kalinga. Several decades of serious researches into these aspects besides enormous archaeological findings have failed to provide any perspective regarding the social formations in the early historic period. One general conclusion which have been invariably relied upon heavily by the scholars is that "there was no caste proliferation in Orissa until 10th and 11th century A.D. And this was essentially due to the fact that there was preponderance of tribal population in the plains/ low land areas.

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It has been argued that "... the caste system developed late in Orissa and when (viz. the c. 10th-11th century A.D.) certain specificities and differences in comparison to Indo-Gangetic model marked it. This was primarily because of the preponderant tribal population and the geographical variations in it (viz. the coastal tract and the hilly/ forested interior). As a result the land grants to Brahmans and the extension of agriculture implied the conversion of most of the tribes into Sudras, which converged with the process of their peasantisation. Alongside this their chiefs were absorbed as Kshatriyas. This implied the absence of any rigid polarization. The classic four fold Varna system continued to remain largely notional as in practice the two-tier structure with the numerous intermediary occupational castes constituted the functional reality. Consequently, one witnesses the evolution of two clearly identifiable Varnas, the Brahmins and the Sudras. The Vaishyas were not visible in society, though men of substance appropriated this status for themselves. This implied that the Vaishyas surfaced in the epigraphical sources only occasionally in times of trade. Similarly, the Kshatriyas never had local roots and were created in this period of state formation (viz. clan to caste society) that saw shifts in the identity of *adibasi* chieftains who invented this category for themselves. The rise of the Kshatriyas/ Karanas was a feature associated with the emergence of feudalism."[4] Further, it is stated that "in the early historical period the tribal society in Orissa had undergone certain socio-economic changes that too led to the formation of the state."[5]

Attempts have been made by scholars to highlight the importance of tribe-caste continuum in the formation of society and state in Orissa in the early historic period. As stated by Seneviratne "Early state formation in Kalinga was the result of the autochthonous forces and influences of the Mauryan occupation of the area".[6] Seneviratne further asserted that before the Mauryan conquest of Kalinga, there were certain pre-state internal developments such as "the emergence of an agrarian base, a demographic expansion, rudimentary craft specialization, a developing exchange network, a degree of social differentiation and emergence of spheres of political influence."[7]

Archaeological evidences as available to us at present point to the existence of numerous resource bases in different parts of Odisha in early historic period which help us in understanding the socio-economic condition of the given society. Benudhar Patra while discussing about urbanism in ancient Orissa stated that "The dated evidence for the emergence of urban centres in the Orissan context can be traced back to the period of Ashokan invasion of Kalinga in the 3rd century B.C. which is tangibly attested by the excavations at Dhauli and Jaugada,

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the two provincial head quarters of the Kalinga province of Ashoka's empire. The existence of urban centres prior to this time can not be entirely ruled out."[8] S.K. Panda's arguments also proceed in the same line. From the prehistoric times the economic development of Orissa was marked by agrarian economy which subsequently transformed into urban economy, which is proved by the Neolithic settlements in Orissa and their material culture. State formation in early Orissa, with Mauryan occupation of Kalinga, also led to the process of urbanization. It further accelerated during the time of Kharavela. With the process of state formation various political centres emerged with fortified settlements such as Sisupalgarh, Jaugada, Asurgarh and Radhanagar. The economic factors such as the development of trade, arts and crafts which is proved by the recovery of coins, knobbed ware from different sites of Orissa, coastal ports, trade routes and also artefacts such as pottery, beads, metal objects and coins from early historical sites. They contributed to the development of urbanization in early historic Orissa".[9]

It is known to us that specialization in various arts and crafts is an essential feature of urban economy.[10] From archaeological findings several professions are identified. These are bead making, terracotta and jewellery production, cotton industry, wooden industry, cart making, boat building, production of musical instruments, basket production, garland making; glass, bone and ivory industries etc. Evidences about the same are found from Sisupalgarh excavation, Khandagiri and Udayagiri caves, Dhauli and Jaugada excavations. So evidently there was proliferation of arts and crafts. "The different specialized professional groups served the necessity of the urban society. There were some specific professions like making of basket, garland making and making of musical instruments which show a sophisticated urban culture and it served the needs of the urban elite".[11] Inspite of the visible presence of Brahmanas and several professional groups it has been argued that the classic form of caste was absent in Odisha during the early historic period.

The absence of a structured caste system prior to 10th-11th century A.D. is a question that needs to be dealt with properly. It is to be seen whether four fold *Varna* hierarchy was existing in Orissa prior to 10th-11th century A.D. or not.

The earliest references about the existence of Brahmanas in Orissa are found in Ashokan Rock Edicts and the Hathigumpha inscription of Kharavela. Inscriptional evidences state about continuous Brahmanical immigration to the land of Orissa from the 5th–6th century A.D. onwards. The state welcomed and patronized them in order to create socio-economic awareness. "Tradition relates", says John beams[12] "that the

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original Brahmanas of Orissa were all extinct at the time of the rise of the Ganga Vamsa line of Kings, but that 10,000 Brahmanas were induced to come from Kanauj and settled in Jajpur the sacred city on the Vaitarani river."

During the Sulki rule (6th century A.D.), Nanda rule (c. 6th century A.D.), Sailodbhava rule (7th century A.D.) and Bhaumakara rule we find innumerable inscriptional evidences regarding the migration of the Brahmanas from north and central India. The Brahmanas are well associated with the *Jajamani* System which had a gradual growth in Orissan society. It is through this system that the castes are bound together and the system is more or less universal in India. In the Jajamani system the interest of all the Varnas are looked after. The earliest reference about the Jajamani system is found from the Dharmalingeswar plate of Ananta Varman I of early Gangas of Kalinga.[13] For performing a sacrifice, a *Jajaman* requires the essential services and goods of other Varnas with Brahmanas. There are also references about Brahmana officers who were appointed for the protection of the people in villages and towns. This is mentioned by Apastambha.[14]

Kshatriyas occupying the next important position after the Brahmanas in the *Varna* hierarchy are found mentioned not only in the Brahminical literature but also in the epigraphic records. Hiuen Tsang's accounts, the inscriptions of Nanda Kingdom, Mathara Kings, Sailodbhava rulers, Sulki rulers and the Bhaumakara rulers etc. state about the status of the ruling lineages in Orissa. The inscriptions invariably mention that the king desires happiness for Go-Brahmana and Praja, meaning thereby the Cows, the Brahmins and the subject people.[15]

The Vaisyas are placed third in the *Varna* category. The original work of the Vaisyas was agriculture and cattle rearing. It may be because of industrialization, formation of guilds and popularity of Jainism among the Vaisyas that they developed contempt for manual labour and dissociated themselves from agriculture and got inclined towards trade and commerce. Reference to existence of Vaisya community in Orissa may be traced back to 6th century B.C. Tapasu and Vallika the two merchants of Utkal are regarded as the first lay disciples of Buddha. This fact is mentioned in the 'Mahabhaga' of *Vinaya Pitaka*, the *Angutara Nikaya* and the Jatakas. We find references in the early inscriptions of Orissa about donations made in favour of the Vaisya individuals. The Chicacole Plates of Madhukamarnava[16] refer to the constitution of three villages into Vaisya *agrahara*. This was made in favour of a scion of Vaisya *Kula Vamsa* called as Erapa Nayaka dwelling

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in the Dantapura. We find a number of *Vanikas* working either as writers or engravers of the royal charters towards the close of the first millennium A.D.

The Sudras occupied the lowest ladder of the four fold division of the *Varna* system. Although the Sudras were subjected to lot of disabilities in Indian context, the Sudras in Orissa broke down the restriction laid upon them and enjoyed the honourable status in the society according to their own merit. The Sudras appeared in Oriya society in a very early stage of Orissa history. They are associated with diverse professions. There is clear-cut reference to a Sudra *Vaishayapati* in the Kanas Copper Plate[17] of Sri Lokavigraha belonging to the 7th century A.D. Hieun Tsang and Itsing mentioned in their writings about kings of Sudra stock. "The presence of Sudra Governor in Orissa (during 7th & 8th century A.D.) clearly denotes the fact that the Sudras (in Orissa) were not completely saddled with economic, politico-legal, social and religious disabilities".[18] We find references to Suvarna Vithi, Svarna Vithi, Suvarna Ralondigrama (village of goldsmiths); Kumbhara padrakagrama (village of potters); *Tela tata Vishaya, Tellavalli Vishaya* (the district of the oilmen); *Gauda Siminillinigrama* (village of cowherds); *Gudda Vishaya, Gudda Sarkarakagrama, Madhu Vatakagrama* (the village of sweet makers); and *Napita Vatakagrama* (village of barbers) in the inscriptions of the early Medieval period of Orissan history.

To specify certain arts and crafts, there is sculptural representation of various ornaments like bangles, girdles and ear studs in the Java-Vijay gumpha of Khandagiri Udayagiri hills.[19] Kalinga is also found mentioned in the Kautilya's *Arthasastra* as producing the best type of cotton.[20] There was also evidences of the wooden industry, 'cushioned bench', bed-steads, tables, sofas, carts, chariots driven by horses and boat making industry, the representation of which are found in the sculptures in the Ranigumpha and Anantagumpha of Khandagiri and Udayaigiri.[21] The boat making tradition is also found from excavations in the Golbai Sasan of Puri district.[22] Besides there are also sculptural representation of a number of musical instruments like *Vina, Venu, Mridanga, Muraja, Samtala, Bheri* and *Samkha* in the Khandagiri and Udayagiri caves. The fifth line of the Hathigumpha inscription refers to the instrumental music.[23] Making of stone objects was also an important profession. The earliest example of stone sculpture is the Dhauli elephant. Carving of caves gathered momentum during Kharavela's time and in Sisupalgarh large structure of fortification made by dressed laterite stone is also noticed. From the excavations of Sisupalgarh, Jaugarh and Dhauli varieties of pottery has been

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discovered. There are also evidences of basket making, leather works, glass, and ivory industries, which are noticed from different excavations. Some modern articles like trays, toilet boxes, fans, umbrellas and money were used by the people.[24] All these inscriptional and archaeological evidences obviously lead us to conclude that there was caste proliferation in Orissa by first century B.C. In the Bhauma charters there are references to the weavers, cowherds, distillers as well as brewers, which again confirm to caste proliferation.[25] The Grant of Jayastambha of 9th century A.D. referred to the existence of labourers, grinders and distillers as well.[26] The large scale temple building activity from 7th century A.D. onwards in Orissa must have been due to the existence of a polarized society in which Brahmanas were exercising their influence.

From the discussion above we may safely reject the contention that the caste system developed in Orissa at a later stage and both the coastal tract and the hilly/ forested country were being inhabited by tribal population. Further it may also be deduced that people involved in the carnages of Kalinga war of Ashoka during 3rd century B.C. were not mostly tribals. This is a hypothesis, which is not acceptable because Ashoka had drawn a demarcation line between the people in the coastal tract and people living in the forest interiors.

Biswamoy Pati drew the attention of scholars to the dynamics of caste formation and the displacement of tribals in pre-colonial Orissa, a process that saw them shift from the plains to the hills.[27] Archaeological and ethno-archaeological investigations as well as settlement theories provide us completely different picture as regards the habitational preferences of the tribals. Ethno-archaeological research in India during the last three decades have led archaeologists to believe that the primitive communities/tribes now living in forest environments are direct descendants of prehistoric hunting-gathering communities. Significant advances have been made by scholars who have tried their best to correlate the living lifestyle of the tribals with the prehistoric archaeological cultures.[28]

Further in regard to original habitation of the tribes it is also necessary to delve into observations made by anthropologists. Bhagirathi Nepak[29] studied the inhabitants of the Bonda hills. "Bondas" live on the hills. Bondas claim their descent from primitive hunter-gatherers. The Bonda folks say that "They are the kings and subjects, Zamindars and slaves of the Bonda hills". Civilization has no meaning for them. But once the Bonda girls/ boys of the hills fell in love with the Bonda girls/ boys of the plains and marry, they never like to go back to their original homelands. On the basis of these evidences, it

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may be deduced that the prehistoric hunter gatherers of the uplands came down to the plains during Neolithic and Neolithic-Chalcolithic peirods and started leading sedentary lives. With the infiltration of Sanskrit speaking elites from the north and introduction of copper and iron into their subsistence activities that life style of the people got transformed. This provided the background for the development of urbanism which characterized the early historic culture of Odisha on the eve of Kalinga War of Ashoka.

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